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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

ELECTION 2026

Campaign season starts with rush of Democrats

Retirements spark aspirations for many in state party, while Republicans produce few candidates

By Rick Pearson
Chicago Tribune

More than seven months before votes are cast, Illinois' 2026 political campaign season officially kicks off this week as candidates for federal, state and county offices

fan out across the state to gather petition signatures to appear on the March 17 primary ballot.

The Tuesday launch date to begin gathering voter signatures is a month earlier this year due to legislation approved last year that also advanced the date for candi-

dates to file their petitions to Oct. 27, rather than the end of November.

It's the latest chapter in an unusual midterm election cycle that has seen veteran federal lawmakers announce their retirements at the end of their terms in January 2027, creating open-seat races for U.S. Senate, four congressional seats and state comptroller, as well as several legislative seats,

as politicians aspire to climb the political ladder.

U.S. Sen. Dick Durbin's decision to retire after five terms has prompted U.S. Reps. Raja Krishnamoorthi, a five-termer from Schaumburg, and Robin Kelly, a six-term lawmaker from Matteson, to seek the Democratic nomination to succeed him. That primary race also includes Lt. Gov. Juliana Stratton.

Adding to Kelly's open 2nd Congressional District seat and Krishnamoorthi's 8th Congressional District seat are the retirement announcements of 14-term, 81-year-old U.S. Rep. Jan Schakowsky of Evanston in the 9th Congressional District and 15-term, 83-year-old U.S. Rep. Danny Davis of Chicago in the 7th

Turn to Campaigns, Page 2



Soraya Alem and Jarvi Schneider, founders of Otter Oaks Farm, at one of their plots on July 3 at Legends Farm in Chicago. Alem and Schneider are a part of the Windy City Harvest Apprenticeship program, which is organized through the Chicago Botanic Garden. **AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

They're here. They're queer. They're farming.

A new crop of LGBTQ farmers is more visible and vocal

By Nara Schoenberg | Chicago Tribune

Laid off by a bar during the COVID pandemic, Jarvi Schneider turned to the internet for job leads.

The Chicago Botanic Garden was offering a training program for would-be farmers that included paid, hands-on experience, and Schneider signed up. That led to a business class and four years growing vegetables at a shared plot in Bronzeville.

Now Schneider, who is transgender and uses they/them pronouns, is taking the next step with their spouse, Soraya Alem.

The couple is leasing a 43-acre farm in McHenry County, with the intention to buy.

"Unlike a regular job that you go to, where maybe it's not what you want to be doing, it's rewarding to have a spiritual and emotional connection to what you're doing," Schneider, 36, said of farming. "And then it's also it's your business, and you're in charge of it."

Schneider and Alem are part of a new wave of LGBTQ farmers who are more visible and better organized than previous generations, with "convergences" — or regional grassroots gatherings, support resources such as the Queer Farmer Network and farm websites that include the owners' LGBTQ identities.

The Department of Agriculture's census of farmers and ranchers doesn't track gender or sexual orientation, so data is very limited. But enterprising researchers crunched the agriculture census numbers for two-person farms and found that 1.2% of those farmers were in same-sex marriages.

That equates to about 24,000 LGBTQ farmers in the U.S. And that number is likely a big undercount because the findings, published in 2020 in the journal Society & Natural Resources, don't include LGBTQ farmers who aren't married, aren't

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Lawmakers flee Texas to Chicago to thwart GOP effort

Move by Democratic House members aims to deny congressional redistricting push

By Rick Pearson
and Jeremy Gornier
Chicago Tribune

Opting to use what Texas politicians called a nuclear option, Democratic members of the Texas House of Representatives arrived in Chicago on Sunday under threat of fines and arrest to deny Republicans the quorum they need to redraw five congressional districts aimed at helping President Donald Trump and the national GOP maintain a U.S. House majority in next year's midterm elections.

A supportive Illinois Gov. JB Pritzker was meeting the Texas Democrats when they landed Sunday evening at O'Hare International Airport. Pritzker issued a statement echoing Texas Democratic arguments that Republicans were using a special legislative session in Austin, aimed at providing relief for last month's flood victims in the state's Hill Country, to please Trump and "as political cover to push through a racially gerrymandered congressional map."

"This is not a decision we make lightly, but it is one we make with absolute moral clarity," state Rep. Gene Wu, the chair of the Texas House Democratic Caucus, said in a statement.

"We're leaving Texas to fight for Texans," Wu said. "We will not allow disaster relief to be held hostage for a Trump gerrymander. We're not walking out on our responsibilities; we're walking out on a rigged system that refuses to listen to the people we represent. As of today, this corrupt special session is over."

Turn to Texas, Page 2

INSIDE

Israeli official's visit to flashpoint holy site decried

Israel's far-right national security minister prayed at Jerusalem's most sensitive holy site, triggering regional condemnation. Hospitals in Gaza said 33 more Palestinians seeking food aid were killed by Israeli fire. **Nation & World**

Defense continued to rule at Bears' Family Fest

The team's defense looked good and the offense struggled during Sunday's practice before a crowd of about 23,000 fans. That's been the case for most of the summer's training camp. **Chicago Sports**

A Peruvian mother seeks a miracle for her boys

The twins, both fighting tumors, are among many who travel to the US for medical care

By Nell Salzman
Chicago Tribune

In the small family restaurant in Rogers Park Monday evening, Walter Guevara sat at a table and devoured yucca fries and Peruvian-style rice with stewed chicken, hungry despite his numerous cancer treatments.

The 18-year-old and his twin, José, are both fighting tumors. But after Walter experienced years of what his family describes as medical mistreatment in Peru, their mother, Maria Ysabel, decided to seek medical care in the United States. She saved money, filled out an application and waited

months as Walter's condition steadily declined before learning she and her sons had received their visas.

Last week, she cried tears of gratitude for the care Walter has received since their arrival to the U.S. this March, including their short trip from Rochester, Minnesota, to Chicago for their country's Independence Day. They are originally from Chiclayo, Peru, so they feel a special connection to Chicago because of Pope Leo XIV, who was born in Chiclayo for eight years.

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Bishop Daniel Turley says goodbye to twin brothers José, left, and Walter Guevara during a Peruvian Independence Day celebration on July 26 at Our Lady of Mercy Parish in Chicago. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

